

Sport



Valletta's Juan Bolanos and Birkirkara's Kurt Zammit in action from yesterday's match. Photo: Nicholas Falzon

Stoppage time goal gives Stripes deserved win

**SIMON FARRUGIA**

A stoppage time goal by Alessandro Coppola gave Birkirkara a valuable three points in their quest to try and climb into the European zone. On the other hand back to reality for Valletta as their fight for survival continues.

For the Citizens this was a second blow over a few days since during the week they were elim-

inated from the Izibet FA Trophy by Mosta. In the league they were on a positive run of two wins and a draw.

As for the Stripes this was their first league commitment under the stewardship of Jose Borg and after a hard fought qualification during the week against lowly Sirens, this result was a welcome tonic for the boys in yellow.

In the first round the match ended in a 1-1 draw.

The match was a rather slow pace one with both goalkeepers rarely being called into action.

Though the Stripes held a bit of territorial superiority. Valletta defended boldly but in the end had to lower their heads when Coppola headed into the net.

The few actions of the first half came all from Birkirkara. Eight minutes from the break a long distance shot by Diakite with Guarnone saving with difficulty. And on 41 minutes the Valletta goalkeeper was once again in the thick of action saving a Kurt Zammit cross shot. Nearing the end of the first half a Coppola shot sailed just over the bar.

Both teams started the second

half brightly. On 68 minutes a Maia free kick missed the desired target. But it was all about enthusiasm and nothing else with play restricted to the midfield area amid a series of mistakes from both sides.

Until finally Birkirkara scored the winner with Coppola heading home a corner to the delight of the Stripes technical staff and the few supporters that made it to the National Stadium.

STANDINGS										
	P	W	D	L	F	A	Pts			
Hamrun	15	12	2	1	36	11	38			
Floriana	15	11	2	2	29	7	35			
Sliema	15	9	3	3	17	7	30			
Marsaxlokk	15	7	4	4	26	15	25			
Hibernians	15	7	3	5	19	14	24			
Birkirkara	16	7	3	6	18	17	24			
Naxxar	15	5	6	4	18	23	21			
Balzan	15	5	4	6	14	20	19			
Valletta	16	4	6	6	16	14	18			
Mosta	15	3	7	5	9	17	16			
Gzira	15	4	3	8	22	24	15			
Santa Lucia	15	3	3	9	9	26	12			
Sirens	15	1	4	10	7	27	7			
Gudja	15	0	6	9	9	27	6			

**BOV Premier League**
2023-24

★★**VALLETTA**



0

A.Guarnone
J. Bolanos
E. Ruiz
O. Barrientos
S. Dimech
G. De Oliveira
J. Azzopardi
V.Filho
N.Micallef
J. Benites
D. Nogueira

Referee
Matthew De Gabriele

BOV Player of the match
Ali Diakite (Birkirkara)

BIRKIRKARA



1

A.Guarnone
J. Bolanos
E. Ruiz
O. Barrientos
S. Dimech
G. De Oliveira
J. Azzopardi
V.Filho
N.Micallef
J. Benites
D. Nogueira

Scorers: A. Coppola 92 min
Yellow cards: P. Mbong, A. Coppola

**BOV Premier League**
2023-24

Today
14:00 Balzan-Santa Lucia
14:00 Hibernians-Floriana
16:15 Naxxar-Gzira
16:15 Sliema-Mosta

Tomorrow
14:00 Gudja-Hamrun
16:15 Sirens-Marsaxlokk

**BOV Challenge League**
2023-24

Today
Promotion Group
14:00 Melita-Senglea
16:30 Pieta-Zurrieq
Relegation Group
14:00 Fgura-Attard
16:30 Zejtun-St. Andrews

Tomorrow
Promotion Group
14:00 Marsa-Zabbar
Relegation Group
14:00 Luqa-Msida
16:30 Lija-Tarxien
16:30 Swieqi-Zebbug